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Headphones Test

looks cool and performs reasonably, the **Creative Tactic 3D Alpha** or the **ASUS Orion PRO** or **Vulcan PRO** are what it's looking for. That said, these headsets leave much to be desired in terms of audio quality and at the prices they retail at, there are far better options available in the "audiophile" category, even for gaming.

The **Creative Tactic 3D Alpha** wins the Best Buy award here. It's a good set but there is nothing especially remarkable about it and while it does offer better value than its competitors, its value is more a product of simple mathematics than appreciable quality. It's a good set nonetheless and while still possessing the signature "boom" of the Creative Tactic series, manages to do a decent job overall.

The others

Sifting through the 17 headsets that we got, we were a bit disappointed at the overall quality on offer. Take the **CM Storm Sirius S** for example, it seems to have a lot going for it, a funky design, an excellent control pod and a true 5.1 driver setup. Unfortunately, the audio from this set was so bad that we didn't enjoy our gaming experience as much as we thought we would. The **Sonuz** by the same company did manage to redeem the **CM Storm** brand with decent audio and the ability to better reproduce the ambient noises in-game, but then the **Ceres 400** pulls the name into the gutter with possibly the worst performance among all the headsets we tested, not the least of which was the awful mic quality.

The **ASUS Orion** and **Orion PRO** are absolutely identical, except for the fact that the **PRO** model comes with an **ROG Spitfire** USB adapter. Both headsets



SteelSeries Diablo III Headset

are pretty good and that's about all we can say for them. The **ROG Spitfire** is a nice adapter to have if you don't have a half-decent sound card and if you do, the **Spitfire** isn't worth the premium over the **Orion**. The **Vulcan PRO** is also a pretty good set and while extremely boomy and imprecise, manages to provide a semblance of a good gaming experience.

The **Sennheiser U320** was another unpleasant surprise, retailing at over ₹10,000, the audio from this set was only slightly better than average. It does come with adapters for your **XBOX** and **TV** but even those don't justify the exorbitant price tag. The volume levels were extremely low and bass almost non-existent and while we do understand that the lack of bass is compensated for by positional accuracy, the **SteelSeries** sets do a far better job at roughly the same price.

Among the better sets was the **Corsair Vengeance 1500**. This set seems quite massive but is quite comfortable. The default sound from this set is far too harsh and bass heavy, with most regular sounds in **Quake** not even audible during

play. With some equalization using the bundled **Vengeance** software though, the set comes into its own and manages to provide an enjoyable experience in games and movies alike.

The **Circle Wager** and **CM Storm Ceres 400** are a class apart. Not because they're good, but because they're by far the worst sets in the comparison. At less than half the price these sets might just be acceptable but at around ₹3,000 for each, they're just not worth it. The **Circle** in particular struggles with heavy action and misses out on many of the all-important sonic cues in-game. The **Ceres** falls flat, literally, and at the very least, this reviewer's ears were aching after just an hour of use.

The unusually named **Cavi-manus** by **Genius** has only one redeeming feature and that is the rumble motors that it has. The headset feels very cheap when you consider the price tag and the audio isn't worthy of a set selling for even half the asking price. The rumble motor is nice though, you can "feel" every shot and explosion and even though the vibrations have

The headsets from **Creative** were the more reasonable ones that we had in the test. The entire **Tactic** line-up is very boomy and has muddy bass that overwhelm other frequencies, especially when there is a lot going on on-screen, but the audio quality is quite good and we would say that these are among the best all-rounder headsets and will do reasonably well in all situations.

The **Creative** sets were good overall, but the exception here is the **Draco**. We would consider this to be one of the worst headsets if we were only judging these sets by their audio quality. Surprisingly, the severe lack of bass worked in its favor, generating audio that was lacking in tonal quality, but faithful in the reproduction of all the elements nonetheless.

Conclusion

This was quite a disappointing test overall. Despite playing with these sets for many days and despite impressing us with their designs and features, we couldn't pick a set that we really liked. There was no set that we were drawn to or reached out for by default when we wanted to play a game. The **SteelSeries** sets came close, but when they retail here for about 30% more than their official prices abroad, they're hard to recommend. They do sound good, but not ₹10,000 good. Manufacturers (other than **SteelSeries** and **ROCCAT** and maybe even **Creative**, if we toe the line a bit) seem to be spending more time and effort on creating funky looking sets rather than actually designing sets that sound good and do their job well. This needs to change, what's the point of a ₹5,000 set when it sounds like a ₹1,000 one? It's like driving a **Premiere Padmini** that looks like a **Ferrari**. Pointless.



The Creative Tactic 3D Alpha

the nasty side effect of ruining the audio, some kid somewhere might get excited. Honestly, ignore this set, save up a bit more and get the **ROCCAT Kave**.